TALK FIVE

5 He Must Increase

"He must increase, but I must decrease."

JOHN 3:30

John's disciples came to him with a complaint. The man he had baptized at the Jordan, the One he had testified about, was now baptizing too. "All men come to him," they told John. They had watched crowds walk into the wilderness to hear their teacher. Now those crowds were going to listen to someone else. They seem to have expected John to be upset. Instead, he told them that his joy was full.

John was glad because he saw Jesus as his Lord, and his work was to help other people recognize Jesus as Lord, too. John had been telling people from the beginning that someone greater was coming.

There were plenty of opportunities for John to claim more for himself. Luke says people "mused in their hearts of John, whether he were the Christ, or not." Priests came from Jerusalem to ask him directly, and he told them he was not the Christ. He was sent to prepare the way. He baptized with water, but the One coming after him would baptize with the Holy Ghost and with fire. As people's expectations of John grew, he kept directing them toward someone else.

I wonder whether that was ever difficult for him. We read about the temptations Jesus faced in the wilderness, but we do not have the same account of John's private struggles. When people already wanted to call him the Christ, did he ever feel tempted to let them? Did he ever wonder whether the work he was doing would accomplish what he hoped? All we know is how he answered people, and his willingness to fulfill the role he was given.

His simple life supported what he said about himself. He wore camel's hair, ate locusts and wild honey, and lived in the wilderness. He made little effort to acquire the comforts or appearance of an important man. People came to

hear him anyway. Eventually, John could literally point to Jesus instead of only speaking about His coming. He was standing with two of his disciples when Jesus walked by, and he said, "Behold the Lamb of God!" The two heard him and followed Jesus. When Jesus turned and asked, "What seek ye?" they asked where He was staying. He answered, "Come and see," and they spent the rest of the day with Him. One was Andrew, who then found his brother Simon Peter and told him they had found the Messiah. John's testimony had led his own disciples to Jesus. Andrew and Peter both later became Apostles of Christ.

So when John's disciples complained about losing the crowds, he reminded them of what he had always told them: "I am not the Christ, but that I am sent before him." "A man can receive nothing," he said, "except it be given him from heaven." These followers were not his to keep. He was supposed to prepare them to receive the Lord.

To explain why this made him happy, John asked them to picture a wedding. The bridegroom's friend helped prepare for the celebration and bring the bride to the groom. When they came together, the friend had a reason to rejoice: what he had worked for was happening. John said, "He that hath the bride is the bridegroom: but the friend of the bridegroom, which standeth and heareth him, rejoiceth greatly because of the bridegroom's voice: this my joy therefore is fulfilled." Jesus was the bridegroom. John was the friend who was glad to hear His voice. Then he said, "He must increase, but I must decrease."

John and Jesus were cousins, and John was a little older, but he understood his place as a servant of the Lord. People in our own lives serve us in a similar way. My parents helped me prepare for baptism because they wanted me to be ready to receive the Lord. The brethren at church teach us to prepare for additional ordinances, and each time we make a covenant in the gospel and keep it, we receive a little more of the Lord into our hearts.

John's testimony also continued to work after his preaching ended. Late in His ministry, Jesus returned to the place across the Jordan where John first baptized. People came to Him and remembered what John had said: "John did no miracle: but all things that John spake of this man were true." They

could now see for themselves that his testimony was true. The Gospel of John says many believed in Jesus there. John was no longer standing beside the river, but people were still finding the Lord because of him.

His disciples thought he was losing something when the crowds left. John told them, "This my joy therefore is fulfilled." He had prepared people to follow his Lord, and now they were doing it. I want to learn to serve with that purpose—to be glad when something I have done helps someone come closer to Christ, whether or not they remember my part in it.

[The speaker continues with his own testimony.]

◆ ◆ ◆

The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.